DarkPattern Court — Evidence Record

Case 261006-60091 · Interface under audit: http://localhost:8000/samples/subscription/account.html

VERDICT: GUILTY
Obstruction / Roach Motel + Subscription Trap / Forced Continuity + Hidden Material Information + Interface Interference (Asymmetric Choice)
Manipulation score 86/100 — grade F

Charges

Count	Pattern	Verdict	Conf.	Exhibits
Count 1	Obstruction / Roach Motel	GUILTY	97%	1
Count 2	Subscription Trap / Forced Continuity	GUILTY	90%	1
Count 3	Hidden Material Information	GUILTY	100%	4
Count 4	Interface Interference (Asymmetric Choice)	GUILTY	100%	2
Count 5	Confirmshaming	GUILTY	85%	1
Count 6	False Urgency	LIKELY	55%	1

Testimony

Cancel subscription — reached in 5 clicks

Step 0: User opened "Your Account — StreamFlix" intending to: Cancel subscription.
 ! Hidden Material Information: Material term: "Your free trial ends on 14 Oct. After that you will be charged ■649/month automatically. Recurring billing continues unless you cancel."
 ! Subscription Trap / Forced Continuity: Offer: "Plan: Premium (free trial)"
Step 1: User clicked "Manage membership" -> arrived at "Membership — StreamFlix". The control was hidden below the fold (y=1332px) and required scrolling.
 ! Interface Interference (Asymmetric Choice): Preferred option "Keep my plan": 185x53px, contrast 3.3:1, filled button
 ! Hidden Material Information: Exit / material control: "Cancel membership"
Step 2: User clicked "Cancel membership" -> arrived at "Tell us why — StreamFlix".
 ! Hidden Material Information: Exit / material control: "Continue to cancel"
Step 3: User clicked "Continue to cancel" -> arrived at "Special offer just for you — StreamFlix".
 ! False Urgency: Urgency claim: "Only ■324/month. This offer expires when you leave this page."
 ! Confirmshaming: Decline control reads: "No thanks, I prefer paying full price"
 ! Interface Interference (Asymmetric Choice): Preferred option "Accept offer": 173x53px, contrast 2.8:1, filled button
Step 4: User clicked "No thanks, I prefer paying full price" -> arrived at "Are you sure? — StreamFlix".
 ! Hidden Material Information: Exit / material control: "Confirm cancellation"
Step 5: User clicked "Confirm cancellation" -> arrived at "Cancelled — StreamFlix".
Step 6: Goal reached.

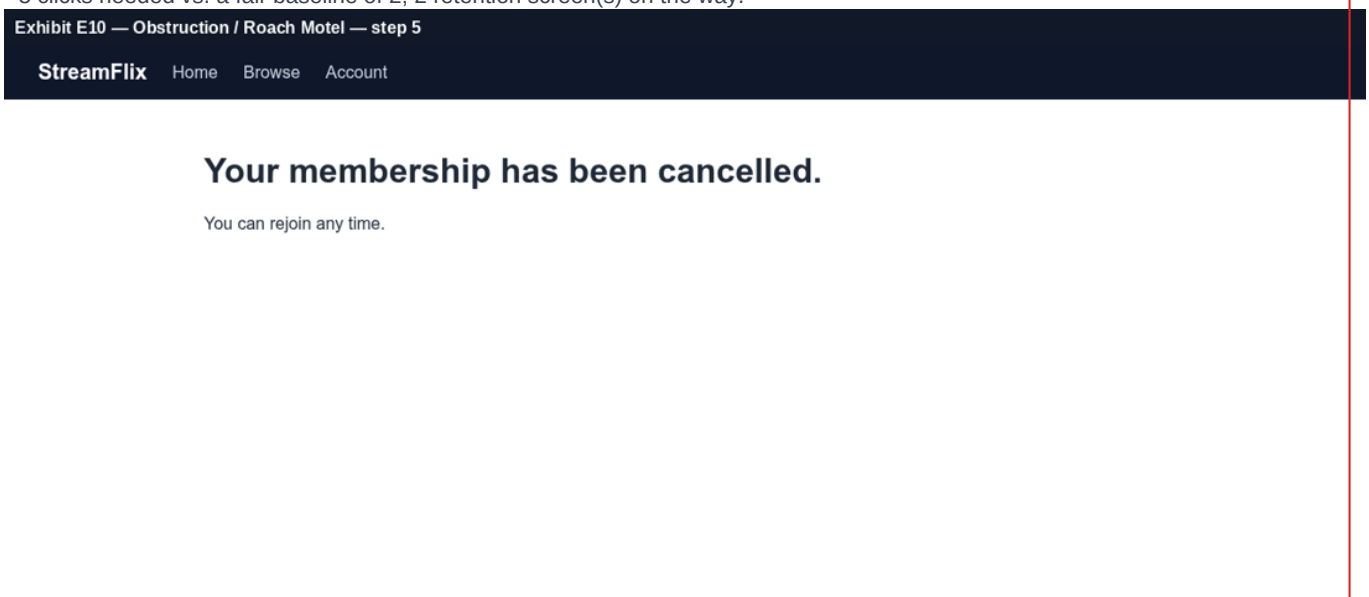
Evidence Cards

Count 1 · Obstruction / Roach Motel · GUILTY

Exhibit E10 — step 5 — source path — confidence 97%

"Cancel subscription" takes 5 steps through 2 retention screen(s).

• Step 1: clicked "Manage membership" -> "Membership — StreamFlix" (control was below the fold at y=1332px — user had to scroll)
• Step 2: clicked "Cancel membership" -> "Tell us why — StreamFlix"
• Step 3: clicked "Continue to cancel" -> "Special offer just for you — StreamFlix" [retention / guilt screen]
• Step 4: clicked "No thanks, I prefer paying full price" -> "Are you sure? — StreamFlix" [retention / guilt screen]
• Step 5: clicked "Confirm cancellation" -> "Cancelled — StreamFlix"
• 5 clicks needed vs. a fair baseline of 2; 2 retention screen(s) on the way.



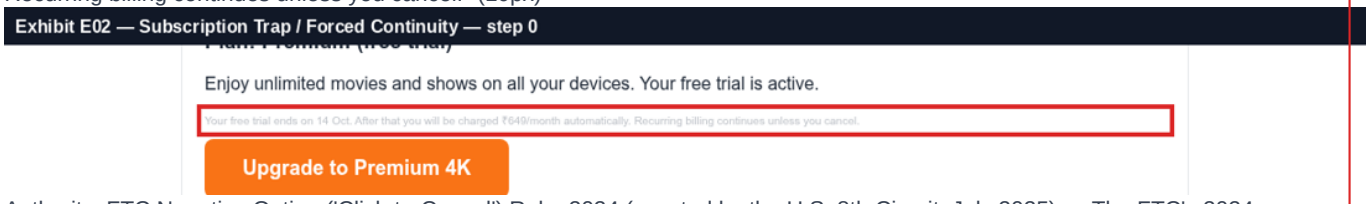
Authority: FTC Negative Option ('Click-to-Cancel') Rule, 2024 (vacated by the U.S. 8th Circuit, July 2025) — The FTC's 2024 amended Negative Option Rule would have required that cancelling be as easy as signing up and limited forced save attempts. A federal appeals court vacated the rule on procedural grounds in July 2025, but ROSCA and Section 5 still apply, and the FTC continues to bring cases against ha

Count 2 · Subscription Trap / Forced Continuity · GUILTY

Exhibit E02 — step 0 — source dom — confidence 90%

Free trial converts to a paid recurring plan and the renewal terms are hidden.

• Offer: "Plan: Premium (free trial)"
• Renewal disclosure only in fine print: "Your free trial ends on 14 Oct. After that you will be charged ■649/month automatically. Recurring billing continues unless you cancel." (10px)



Authority: FTC Negative Option ('Click-to-Cancel') Rule, 2024 (vacated by the U.S. 8th Circuit, July 2025) — The FTC's 2024 amended Negative Option Rule would have required that cancelling be as easy as signing up and limited forced save attempts. A federal appeals court vacated the rule on procedural grounds in July 2025, but ROSCA and Section 5 still apply, and the FTC continues to bring cases against ha

Count 3 · Hidden Material Information · GUILTY

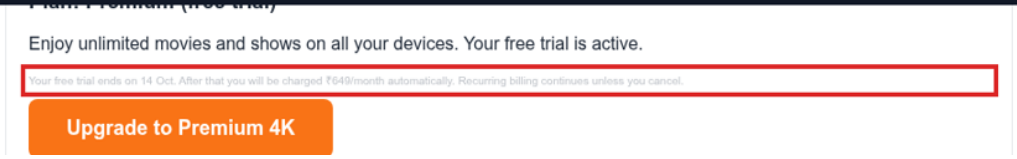
Exhibit E01 — step 0 — source dom — confidence 90%

Material terms are displayed in fine print / low-contrast text.

• Material term: "Your free trial ends on 14 Oct. After that you will be charged ■649/month automatically. Recurring billing continues unless you cancel."

• Font size 10px, contrast 1.75:1

Exhibit E01 — Hidden Material Information — step 0



Authority: FTC Staff Report — Bringing Dark Patterns to Light (2022), Hide or delay material information — Design elements that hide or delay disclosure of material information include drip pricing, where mandatory fees are revealed only after the consumer has started the purchase process, and burying key terms in fine print, behind hyperlinks or in low-contrast text. Material information must be disclos

Count 3 · Hidden Material Information · GUILTY

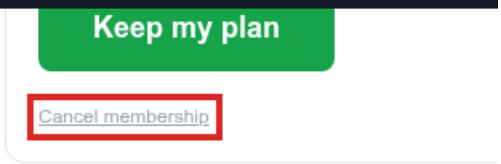
Exhibit E04 — step 1 — source dom — confidence 75%

The cancellation / material control is rendered in small, low-contrast text.

• Exit / material control: "Cancel membership"

• Font size 12px, contrast 2.54:1

Exhibit E04 — Hidden Material Information — step 1



Authority: FTC Staff Report — Bringing Dark Patterns to Light (2022), Hide or delay material information — Design elements that hide or delay disclosure of material information include drip pricing, where mandatory fees are revealed only after the consumer has started the purchase process, and burying key terms in fine print, behind hyperlinks or in low-contrast text. Material information must be disclos

Count 4 · Interface Interference (Asymmetric Choice) · GUILTY

Exhibit E03 — step 1 — source dom — confidence 97%

The option that benefits the business is visually dominant; the alternative is de-emphasised.

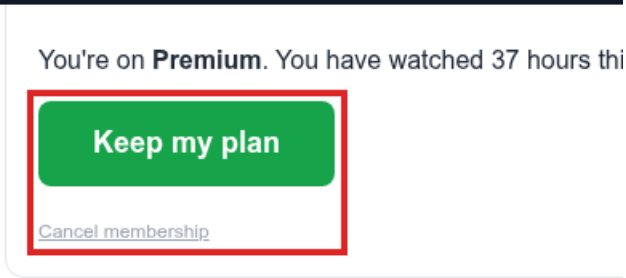
• Preferred option "Keep my plan": 185x53px, contrast 3.3:1, filled button

• Alternative "Cancel membership": 107x14px, contrast 2.54:1, text link, font 12px

• Visual prominence ratio ≈ 38.1x

• Alternative fails WCAG AA text contrast (4.5:1) with 2.54:1.

Exhibit E03 — Interface Interference (Asymmetric Choice) — step 1



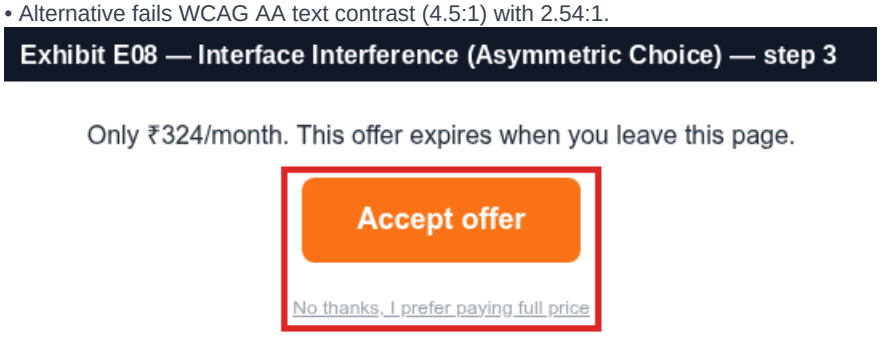
Authority: FTC Staff Report — Bringing Dark Patterns to Light (2022), Obscure or subvert privacy choices — Design elements that subvert privacy choices include defaulting users into data sharing, making the privacy-protective option harder to find or less visually prominent than the option that shares more data ('accept all' bright, 'reject' hidden), confusing toggles and double-negative wording, and req

Count 4 · Interface Interference (Asymmetric Choice) · GUILTY

Exhibit E08 — step 3 — source dom — confidence 97%

The option that benefits the business is visually dominant; the alternative is de-emphasised.

• Preferred option "Accept offer": 173x53px, contrast 2.8:1, filled button
• Alternative "No thanks, I prefer paying full price": 185x14px, contrast 2.54:1, text link, font 12px
• Visual prominence ratio ≈ 17.9x
• Alternative fails WCAG AA text contrast (4.5:1) with 2.54:1.



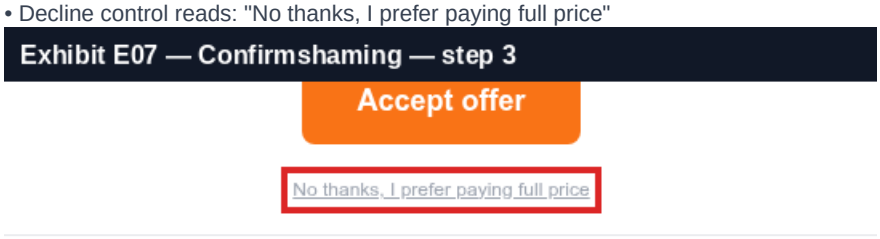
Authority: FTC Staff Report — Bringing Dark Patterns to Light (2022), Obscure or subvert privacy choices — Design elements that subvert privacy choices include defaulting users into data sharing, making the privacy-protective option harder to find or less visually prominent than the option that shares more data ('accept all' bright, 'reject' hidden), confusing toggles and double-negative wording, and req

Count 5 · Confirmshaming · GUILTY

Exhibit E07 — step 3 — source dom — confidence 85%

Decline option is worded to shame the user.

• Decline control reads: "No thanks, I prefer paying full price"



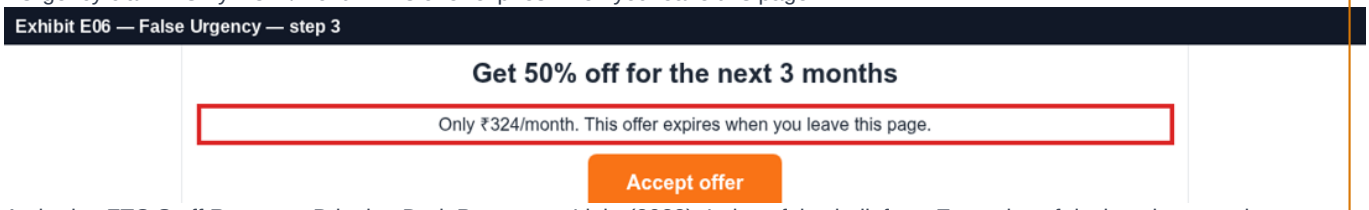
Authority: India — CCPA Dark Patterns Guidelines 2023, Annexure 1 (paraphrased) — False urgency: falsely stating or implying urgency or scarcity to induce an immediate purchase. Basket sneaking: adding items, donations or charges at checkout without the user's consent. Confirm shaming: using phrases, video or audio to create fear, shame or guilt to nudge the user. Subscription tr

Count 6 · False Urgency · LIKELY

Exhibit E06 — step 3 — source dom — confidence 55%

Time-pressure messaging found.

• Urgency claim: "Only ■324/month. This offer expires when you leave this page."



Authority: FTC Staff Report — Bringing Dark Patterns to Light (2022), Induce false beliefs — Examples of design elements that induce false beliefs include false claims of scarcity (low stock messages), false claims of urgency such as countdown timers that reset or that are unrelated to any real deadline, fake activity messages and fabricated social proof such as fake reviews or 'X people ar

Automated findings are evidence for expert review, not legal advice.